

Why do people confronted with the same circumstances arrive at different judgements, make different choices and respond differently to the same opportunities for change?

We often explain these differences in terms of personality, experience, knowledge or individual interests. Yet these explanations may not reach the deeper evaluative structures through which people interpret their circumstances and determine how they ought to respond.

A recent post by Shai Tubali in *Big Think*, exploring three philosophers' perspectives on what humans should preserve in the age of artificial intelligence, prompted me to reflect on a deeper question: what do these perspectives reveal about how we see the world and how our worldviews shape our judgements and actions? The post brings together the perspectives of Michael Hauskeller, Susan Wolf and Luciano Floridi, highlighting the importance of questioning, caring about what is worthwhile, and recognising the significance of human intention and uniqueness.

Beyond the immediate debate about AI, I believe these ideas offer a valuable lens through which to explore the relationship between human judgement and worldview.

Three philosophical contributions, in particular, offer a useful point of departure. Hauskeller draws attention to our capacity to question and live with uncertainty. Wolf explores the relationship between meaning, caring and worthwhile engagement. Floridi examines the significance of human agency, intention and the processes through which outcomes acquire meaning.

Although these philosophers approach different questions, their contributions converge on a fundamental concern: understanding human beings requires more than examining what they know or what they do. We must also consider how they evaluate their world, what matters to them and how they understand their capacity to act.

These concerns resonate with the Worldview LOA framework, which examines the relationship between three dimensions of human evaluation: Legitimacy, Relational Obligation and Agency.

Legitimacy: The importance of questioning what we take for granted

Michael Hauskeller's philosophical contribution draws attention to something easily overlooked in a world that prizes certainty, answers and solutions: the value of remaining open to questions that resist definitive resolution.

Human judgement involves more than accumulating information. It requires us to examine assumptions, question established interpretations and consider whether the conclusions we reach are justified. Sometimes, intellectual maturity means recognising the limits of our knowledge rather than prematurely closing a question.

This perspective has important implications for understanding legitimacy.

Legitimacy concerns the evaluative beliefs through which people determine what is right, acceptable, justified or worthy of support. These beliefs influence how individuals interpret events, assess competing claims and decide which courses of action they regard as defensible.

What one person considers legitimate, another may regard as questionable or unacceptable. Such differences do not necessarily arise because one individual possesses better information than another. They may reflect different assumptions about what constitutes fairness, appropriate authority, responsible conduct or a desirable outcome.

Consider two executives confronted with a major organisational restructuring. Both may agree that change is necessary. Yet one may regard the restructuring as a legitimate response to economic pressures, while the other questions whether its consequences for employees can be justified.

Their disagreement concerns more than the merits of the strategy. It involves the standards through which they evaluate what is legitimate.

Hauskeller's emphasis on questioning reminds us that these standards should not simply be assumed or accepted without reflection. The Worldview LOA perspective invites us to examine how such evaluative beliefs shape our judgements and, consequently, our responses to the world around us.

The important insight is that we do not respond to circumstances as they are alone; we respond to circumstances as we interpret and evaluate them.

Relational Obligation: What we care about shapes what we do

Susan Wolf's philosophical work on meaning offers a second insight. Human flourishing is not simply a matter of pursuing whatever we happen to desire, nor is it reducible to satisfying externally defined standards. Meaningful engagement involves caring about things that are genuinely worthwhile and becoming actively involved in them.

This highlights the importance of the relationship between personal commitment and the objects of that commitment.

We are not detached observers of the world. Our relationships, responsibilities, loyalties and convictions influence what we notice, what we consider important and what we are prepared to do. These commitments give situations significance beyond their immediate practical consequences.

This is closely related to the Relational Obligation dimension of Worldview LOA.

Relational Obligation concerns the obligations people perceive within their relationships and the commitments that influence how they believe they ought to respond to others. These obligations may arise from formal responsibilities, but they can also emerge from trust, reciprocity, professional identity, loyalty or a deeply held sense of responsibility.

Imagine a manager implementing a new organisational strategy that promises improved performance but creates significant uncertainty for employees. The manager may recognise the strategic rationale while simultaneously feeling responsible for protecting the dignity, development and wellbeing of the people affected.

The resulting judgement cannot be understood solely by examining the manager's assessment of strategic necessity. We must also understand the relationships and obligations that shape the manager's interpretation of the situation.

Importantly, relational obligations do not always point in the same direction. An executive may experience competing obligations towards employees, shareholders, customers and colleagues. Determining how to respond requires judgement about which commitments matter, how they should be reconciled and what responsible action demands.

Wolf's contribution helps illuminate why engagement is not simply a function of agreement or self-interest. What people care about, and how they understand the worth of their commitments, influences how they participate in the world.

Through the Worldview LOA lens, we can therefore explore why people who accept the same strategic objective may nevertheless differ substantially in their willingness to support it and in the ways they choose to do so.

Agency: The relationship between intention and action

Luciano Floridi's work provides a third perspective by drawing attention to the significance of agency, intention, provenance and the processes through which outcomes are produced.

The meaning of an outcome does not always reside in the outcome itself. We may also care about who produced it, how it came about and what the action expresses about the intentions and responsibilities of those involved.

This raises important questions about how people understand their capacity to influence events and take responsibility for their actions.

The Agency dimension of Worldview LOA concerns the possibilities and constraints people perceive when considering what they can do. It directs attention to how individuals understand their own capacity to act within the circumstances they inhabit.

This is not equivalent to possessing formal authority or objective resources. Two people with comparable positions and capabilities may experience their opportunities very differently. One may perceive a meaningful opportunity to challenge an established practice; another may believe that resistance is futile or that the circumstances leave little room for alternatives.

These perceptions matter because the transition from judgement to action is not automatic.

An executive may believe that a proposed course of action is legitimate and feel a strong obligation to support it, yet remain uncertain about whether they can influence its implementation. Alternatively, an individual may perceive considerable freedom to act while questioning whether the available options are ethically defensible.

Agency therefore cannot be understood independently of the evaluative and relational dimensions of human experience.

Floridi's attention to intention and the processes through which outcomes emerge further underscores the importance of considering how people understand their involvement in what happens. Responsibility involves more than occupying a position from which decisions are made. It also concerns the relationship between one's judgements, intentions and actions.

Within Worldview LOA, the question becomes how people interpret their capacity to act, what constraints they perceive and how these perceptions influence their responses to the circumstances they face.

Bringing the three dimensions together: From understanding to reflection

The philosophical contributions of Hauskeller, Wolf and Floridi illuminate three interconnected aspects of human judgement.

Legitimacy concerns how we determine what is right and defensible. Relational Obligation concerns what we feel responsible for in relation to others. Agency concerns what we believe we can do.

These dimensions are analytically distinct, but they operate within the same human experience. Our understanding of what is legitimate influences the commitments we are willing to uphold. Our relational obligations shape how we interpret our responsibilities. Our perceptions of agency influence whether and how we translate our judgements into action.

This relationship offers a way to understand why people confronted with similar circumstances may respond differently. Their actions are shaped not only by external conditions or immediate incentives, but also by the evaluative structures through which they make sense of their world.

For organisational leaders, this has particular significance. Strategies, structures and formal responsibilities matter, but they do not fully explain how people interpret change, negotiate competing obligations or decide whether they can and should act.

Understanding these underlying evaluative structures is the starting point for evaluative reflexivity: the capacity to examine how our assumptions, commitments and perceptions of agency shape the judgements we make. Rather than simply asking whether a decision is right or wrong, evaluative reflexivity invites us to explore why we see it as right or wrong, which obligations influence our position, and how our perceptions of what is possible shape our response.

This is where Worldview LOA moves beyond describing differences between people. It provides a lens through which to investigate the relationship between how we see the world and how we act within it.

The Executive Sextant: Finding our position before choosing our course

The Executive Sextant translates this perspective into a practical opportunity for leadership reflection. Drawing on the Worldview LOA framework, it invites executives to examine the evaluative assumptions that influence their decisions and their responses to organisational change.

Like a navigational sextant, the instrument offers a way to establish a position from which to orient oneself. Its purpose is not to prescribe the correct decision or provide a universal answer to complex leadership challenges. Rather, it encourages executives to become more conscious of the worldview through which they interpret their circumstances.

An executive might, for example, explore what makes a proposed transformation legitimate in their eyes, which relationships and obligations weigh most heavily in their judgement, and whether their understanding of their own agency enables or constrains the actions they consider possible.

Such reflection can reveal tensions that might otherwise remain unexamined. An executive may advocate a course of action on strategic grounds while overlooking a relational obligation. Another may recognise what they believe is right but underestimate their capacity to influence the outcome. A third may feel compelled to act without adequately questioning the assumptions underpinning that obligation.

The Executive Sextant provides a structured starting point for exploring these tensions. By bringing legitimacy, relational obligation and agency into view, it supports a more deliberate examination of the relationship between worldview, judgement and action.

The objective is not to eliminate differences in perspective. It is to make those differences more intelligible, enabling executives to reflect on their own positions and engage more thoughtfully with the perspectives of others.

Ultimately, leadership requires more than knowing where an organisation intends to go. It also requires an understanding of how we establish our own position, how that position shapes the course we choose, and how our judgements affect those who travel with us.

Conclusion: Seeing differently, acting differently

The philosophical perspectives explored here invite us to look beyond observable behaviour towards the judgements, commitments and perceptions that give behaviour its meaning.

Hauskeller reminds us of the importance of questioning our assumptions and remaining open to uncertainty. Wolf draws attention to the relationship between meaning, caring and worthwhile engagement. Floridi directs our attention to agency, intention and responsibility.

Worldview LOA brings these concerns into a common interpretive framework, examining how legitimacy, relational obligation and agency shape the ways people evaluate their circumstances and respond to them.

The Executive Sextant builds on this foundation by offering a practical means of reflecting on these dimensions in the context of leadership and organisational change. It invites executives to consider not only the decisions they make, but also the underlying evaluative structures through which those decisions acquire meaning.

The broader implication is that meaningful change requires more than changing external conditions. It also requires an appreciation of how people see those conditions, what they believe is at stake and what they perceive themselves capable of doing.

When we become more conscious of these underlying dimensions, we gain a richer understanding of our own judgements and those of others. We become better positioned to question our assumptions, recognise competing obligations and examine the possibilities for responsible action.

Transformation begins not with changing the world, but with changing the way we see it.